

Emotionally Intelligent Companion Dog Robot with AI-Driven Security and Voice Interaction

Sub Component (Offline Voice Command Recognition)

R26-SE-040

Project Proposal Report

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March 2026

DECLARATION

I declare that this is my own work, and this proposal does not knowingly incorporate any material previously submitted for a degree or diploma at any other university or higher education institution, nor does it contain any material that has been previously published or written by another person apart from where proper acknowledgment is given in the text.

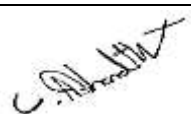
Name	Student ID	Signature
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Table 1

The above candidate is conducting research for their undergraduate Dissertation under my supervision.

Name	Date	Signature
Prof Pradeep Abeygunawardhana	14 th March 2026	

Table 2

ABSTRACT (Maximum 300 words)

This research proposes the development of an Emotionally Intelligent Companion Robot Dog named “Buddy”, designed to provide emotional support, home security monitoring, and natural voice interaction in a smart home environment. The project addresses two major issues in modern societies: loneliness and the limitations of passive home security systems. Many existing robotic companion systems and voice assistants rely heavily on cloud-based processing, which introduces privacy concerns, latency, and dependency on internet connectivity.

The proposed Buddy system uses Edge Artificial Intelligence to process voice commands, facial emotions, and interaction behaviors locally on the device. The robot integrates an offline speech recognition pipeline using wake-word detection and speech-to-text processing, followed by natural language understanding to interpret commands. Additionally, the robot will include an emotion recognition module that analyzes human facial expressions using computer vision techniques to detect emotions such as happiness, sadness, anger, surprise, and neutrality.

The system will track emotional patterns over time and adapt its interactions accordingly. For example, if the robot detects a user experiencing prolonged sadness, it will initiate supportive interactions such as conversation, music playback, or activity suggestions in an attempt to improve the user's emotional well-being.

A mobile application will also be developed to visualize emotional analytics, monitor robot status, and remotely interact with the robot. The expected outcome is an affordable, privacy-preserving robotic companion capable of improving emotional wellbeing while providing practical home monitoring capabilities.

Keywords: Companion Robot, Emotion Recognition, Edge AI, Offline Speech Recognition, Human-Robot Interaction

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to my supervisor, **Prof Pradeep Abeygunawadhrana**, for their invaluable guidance and expertise throughout the development of this proposal.

I also extend my thanks to my group members, Sobiya Anton Suresh and SSY Wickramasinghe, for their collaborative efforts in designing the Buddy Robot system.

Finally, I thank the Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology for providing the platform and resources necessary to undertake this final-year research project.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

- **AI:** Artificial Intelligence
- **CNN:** Convolutional Neural Network
- **NLP:** Natural Language Processing
- **NLU:** Natural Language Understanding
- **SDG:** Sustainable Development Goals
- **WBS:** Work Breakdown Structure

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1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background and Context

Many individuals experience loneliness and lack of companionship in modern urban environments. Elderly individuals, people living alone, and individuals working remotely often experience reduced social interaction. Meanwhile, most home security systems function only as passive surveillance devices without emotional intelligence or interaction capabilities.

Advanced robotic companions such as Sony Aibo demonstrate the potential of social robots to improve human wellbeing and companionship [14], but their extremely high cost makes them inaccessible to most households in developing countries such as Sri Lanka. Additionally, most voice assistants depend on cloud processing, which introduces privacy risks and latency.

This research proposes an affordable emotionally intelligent robot dog called Buddy. The robot integrates voice interaction, emotion recognition, and autonomous behavior to provide companionship while also supporting home monitoring functions. By processing most data locally using edge computing, the system ensures privacy and real-time responsiveness while remaining cost-effective.

1.2 Literature Review

Current market solutions include high-end robotic pets such as Sony Aibo and other socially interactive robots designed for companionship and emotional interaction [7]. Voice assistants commonly rely on cloud-based speech processing systems for command interpretation [1]. Traditional home security systems primarily use cameras and motion sensors but lack social interaction and emotional intelligence [6].

1.3 Research Gap

Existing robotic companions are either extremely expensive or heavily dependent on internet connectivity. Furthermore, most systems do not actively monitor or attempt to improve user emotional wellbeing over time. This research addresses the gap by developing an affordable AI companion robot capable of detecting human emotions, recording emotional trends, and adapting its behavior to improve emotional wellbeing while maintaining privacy through local processing.

2. OBJECTIVE

2.1 Main Objective

To develop a fully offline, privacy-preserving voice interaction system for the Buddy robot that utilizes a two-stage pipeline for wake-word detection and speech recognition, optimized for Sri Lankan English accents, and features an ML-driven intent parser with emotion-adaptive speech synthesis.

2.2 Specific Objectives

Your current specific objectives cover the whole team's work (emotion tracking, mobile app, etc.). You need to expand *your* voice-specific bullets to show the technical depth of your work. Keep your teammates' objectives intact, but replace your voice-related bullet points with the following:

- **Implement a two-stage offline speech pipeline:** Integrate hardware-efficient wake-word detection (e.g., Porcupine) to trigger the local Speech-to-Text (STT) engine, reducing continuous CPU load.
- **Develop an ML-based Natural Language Understanding (NLU) module:** Transition from rule-based keyword matching to an intent classification model (using TF-IDF + Logistic Regression or a lightweight transformer) to accurately map user text to over 50 specific intents.
- **Optimize for regional accents:** Fine-tune the offline speech recognition language model using a custom dataset of Sri Lankan English accent samples to improve local accuracy.
- **Implement confidence thresholding:** Utilize STT confidence scores to prompt users to repeat commands when accuracy falls below a set threshold, ensuring robust interaction.
- **Create emotion-adaptive speech synthesis:** Modulate the robot's Text-to-Speech (TTS) parameters (such as speech rate, volume, and tone) in real-time based on the user's detected emotional state (e.g., speaking softer and slower when the user is sad).

3. METHODOLOGY

The system will be developed using a modular architecture combining multiple artificial intelligence components.

- **Voice Interaction Module**

A two-stage pipeline is implemented:

1. **Wake-word detection** (to be integrated) using Porcupine or Snowboy, ensuring the robot only listens after “Buddy” is spoken.
2. **Offline speech-to-text** using the Vosk model, configured for 16 kHz streaming recognition. Audio is captured via a microphone with threaded processing and queue-based buffering to prevent self-hearing (using an “is speaking” flag).
3. **Intent parsing:** Currently a rule-based engine with 50+ intent categories, context-aware farewell, and conversation history tracking. This will be upgraded to an ML-based classifier (e.g., TF-IDF + Logistic Regression or TinyBERT) for higher accuracy.
4. **Text-to-speech** is handled offline by pyttsx3 with adjustable rate, volume, and female voice selection.

- **Emotion Recognition Module**

A facial emotion recognition system will analyze images captured from the robot's camera. A convolutional neural network model will classify emotions including happiness, sadness, anger, surprise, and neutrality which is a widely used approach in facial emotion recognition research [5].

- **Emotion Monitoring System**

The system will record emotional scores over time. For example:

Monday – Sad 90%, Happy 10%

Tuesday – Sad 70%, Happy 30%

This allows the robot to measure emotional trends and attempt to increase positive emotional states through interaction.

- **Adaptive Emotional Response**

When negative emotions persist, the robot will initiate supportive behaviors such as:

- initiating conversation
- playing music
- telling jokes
- suggesting relaxing activities

- **Hardware Platform**

Raspberry Pi 4 Model B with Camera Module, microphone, speaker, and servo motors for movement. The robot’s autonomous navigation and obstacle avoidance are handled by another team member (SSY).

- **Data Privacy**

All processing occurs on-device; no audio or image data leaves the robot. User consent is obtained for any data collection used in research, and all stored data is anonymized.

4. HIGH-LEVEL SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

The system overview follows a strict pipeline: Voice Input -> Wake Word Detection -> Speech Recognition -> Intent Parser -> Robot Action.

- **Hardware Components:** The system utilizes a microphone module to capture audio input, a Raspberry Pi 4 Model B for processing, and a robot control interface for actuation.
- **Software Components:** The pipeline relies on a wake word detection model, an offline Speech-to-Text engine, and an NLP command parser.
- **Dependencies:** This voice component works together with Sobiya's Face Recognition system for user identification and SSY's Autonomous navigation and obstacle avoidance system.
- **Security & Scalability:** All voice data is processed locally on the device, ensuring no personal data is stored on external servers, thereby guaranteeing user privacy protection.

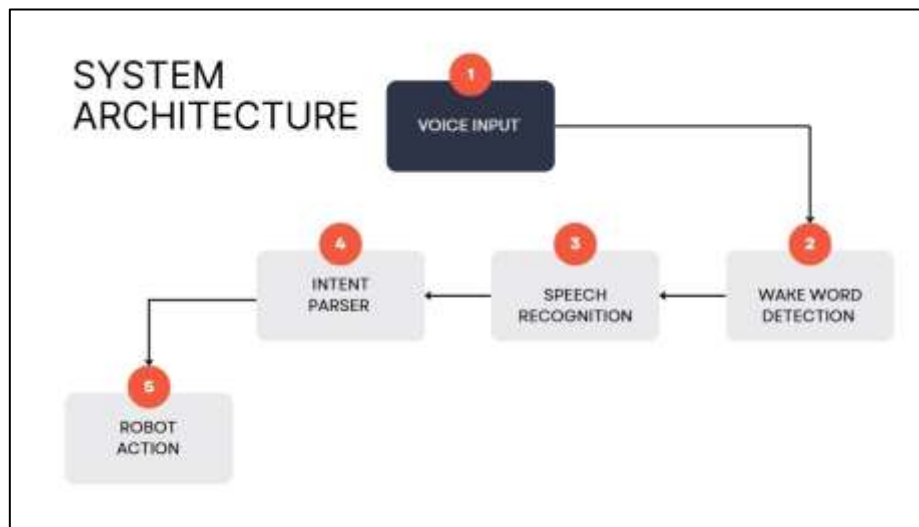


Figure 1

MOBILE APPLICATION

A companion mobile application will be developed to enhance user interaction and monitoring. The application will allow users to view emotional analytics, monitor robot status, and remotely interact with the robot.

Features of the application include:

- Viewing detected emotional statistics
- Monitoring robot activity
- Sending remote commands
- Viewing camera feed
- Visualizing emotional trends through graphs

The application will provide users with insights into emotional patterns and improvements over time.

DATASET

Emotion recognition models will be trained using publicly available datasets such as FER2013 and CK+ which are commonly used for facial expression analysis research [12].

Datasets may include:

- FER2013 facial emotion dataset
- CK+ facial expression dataset
- Locally collected Sri Lankan facial expression samples

The inclusion of local data ensures improved accuracy for regional users.

EVALUATION METRICS

The system performance will be evaluated using several metrics:

Metric	Description
Wake-word detection rate	Percentage of correctly detected “Buddy” utterances
False accept rate	Number of times the robot wakes up to non-wake words
Speech recognition accuracy	Word error rate (WER) on test phrases, including Sri Lankan accented samples
Intent classification accuracy	Precision/recall of intent predictions vs. rule-based baseline
Emotion recognition accuracy	Classification accuracy on validation datasets (FER2013, CK+)
Command execution success rate	Percentage of correctly interpreted and executed commands
Response latency	Time from wake word to robot action (aim for < 2 seconds)
User satisfaction	Subjective feedback via questionnaires
Emotional improvement trends	Pre-/post interaction analysis of user emotional states over time

Table 3

COMMERCIALIZATION

The proposed robot has strong potential for commercialization in several markets including smart homes, elderly care facilities, and personal companionship systems.

The prototype is estimated to cost approximately LKR 60,000–150,000 depending on hardware configuration, making it significantly more affordable than imported robotic companions.

Revenue models could include:

- Direct product sales
- Smart home integration services
- Software upgrades and feature expansions

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

Privacy and ethical considerations are critical in systems that process personal data such as facial images and voice recordings.

All sensitive data will be processed locally on the device whenever possible. Facial images and emotional statistics will not be transmitted to external servers. Participation in emotion data collection will require user consent, and all research data will be anonymized.

FUTURE WORK

While the current prototype already implements a rich conversational engine with offline STT and TTS, several enhancements are planned to fully realise the proposal's novelty:

- **Wake-word integration** to complete the two-stage pipeline and reduce CPU usage.
- **ML-based intent classifier** to replace rule-based parsing for better generalisation.
- **Accent fine-tuning** of the Vosk model using locally collected Sri Lankan English speech samples.
- **Emotion-driven voice modulation** (e.g., slower, softer speech when user is sad) to deepen empathetic interaction.
- **Cloud sync option** (opt-in) for users who want to back up emotional analytics.
- **Integration with smart home IoT devices** for extended functionality.

5. USER REQUIREMENTS

- **Stakeholders:** Smart homes, Elderly care facilities, and Home security systems.
- **Functional Requirements:**
 1. The system must continuously listen for and detect the wake word "Buddy".
 2. The system must convert captured speech into text completely offline.
 3. The system must parse intents to output actions (e.g., follow user, patrol house, respond to commands).
- **Non-Functional Requirements:**
 1. **Privacy:** The system must not rely on cloud infrastructure, ensuring all data remains on the device.
 2. **Performance:** The system must minimize latency to provide real-time interaction.

6. COMMERCIALIZATION PLAN

The target market includes smart homes, elderly care, and home security systems. The value proposition is offering an affordable robot dog that provides emotional interaction combined with security, utilizing a privacy-focused offline AI. The business and revenue model will rely on product sales and smart home integration services. The basic prototype robot dog is estimated to be priced between LKR 60,000 and 150,000, providing a massive competitive advantage over high-end commercial alternatives.

7. BUDGET AND JUSTIFICATION

The Buddy Dog Robot prototype is developed with an approximate budget of LKR 60,000.

Component	Estimated Cost (LKR)	Justification
Raspberry Pi 4	18,000	Required for edge computing and running offline AI models.
Arduino Uno	5,000	Microcontroller for sensor integration.
MG996R Servo Motor (8–10 motors)	20,000	Actuation for the robot's limbs.
HC-SR04 Ultrasonic Sensor	1,500	Required for distance calculation and obstacle avoidance.
MPU6050 Sensor	1,200	Required for balance and movement control.
Raspberry Pi Camera Module	5,000	Required for visual input and face recognition integration.
PCA9685 Servo Driver	2,500	Required to drive multiple servo motors simultaneously.
Battery and Power System	4,000	Power supply for mobile autonomy.
Frame and Mechanical Parts	2,800	Chassis and physical structure.
Total	~60,000	

Table 4

8. WORK BREAKDOWN STRUCTURE (WBS)

The project is divided into distinct phases to manage development effectively:

1. Research and system design
2. AI model development
3. Hardware integration
4. Testing and optimization
5. Final evaluation and documentation

9. GANTT CHART

Phase	Duration
Research and system design	Month 1–2
AI model development	Month 3–4
Hardware integration	Month 5–6
Testing and optimization	Month 7–8
Final evaluation and documentation	Month 9

Table 5



Figure 2

10. REFERENCES LIST

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11.APPENDICES

- **Appendix A:** Ethical Clearance Documents for Voice Data Collection
- **Appendix B:** Complete NLU Intent Mapping Table
- **Appendix C:** Local Sri Lankan English Accent Dataset Documentation